

Windows Phone 8: Microsoft's Only Hope

What makes Windows Phone 8 different from the existing bunch of mobile operating systems? Who should buy a Windows Phone 8 smartphone? What are the options to choose from? Find out



S. AADEETYA

Android as a mobile platform has generated a huge interest among smartphone users across the globe. The 'revolution' has been aided by the availability of a wide array of Android devices in all price ranges, from low-end phones to high-end devices. But the case has been entirely different with Windows Phone 8 devices. Windows Phone 8 is taking time to develop its eco-system, and hence the market is also taking time to adopt this offering of Microsoft.

Ever since Windows Phone 8 has been launched, questions have been raised whether this operating system would be capable of competing against the established duopoly of Android and iOS. Microsoft is trying its best to position its latest operating system as the worthy competitor to Android and iOS.

The introduction of Windows 8 (for desktop) encouraged the company to work on a platform that will be able to converge devices like desktop/laptop, smartphone and tablet, which led to the creation of Windows Phone 8. This is not the first time that we are hearing about Microsoft's attempt to compete in the smartphone space as the company had previously launched Windows Phone 7.5 and then Windows Phone 7.8.

There is something unique about what Windows Phone 8 offers in terms of the whole package, and that certainly makes the industry believe Microsoft means serious busi-

ness. Launched late last year (couple of weeks after Windows 8 made its way), Windows Phone 8 has been appreciated for its clean design interface and ease of use. These features were appreciated by the best in business.

Unlike Android (open source platform) and iOS (Apple's premium platform), Windows Phone 8 came with the stamp of Microsoft and was meant to exist in this space of duopoly. But looking at its developments in 2013, one can say that the figures do not justify the predictions.

The do-the-way-you-like *mantra* became synonymous with Android and the interest from developers was overwhelming (with more than 700,000 apps developed). But with Windows Phone 8, Microsoft is working really hard to get the developers' attention, who have been working in their comfort zone. Windows Phone 8 has certainly brought a different dimension to the mobile platform space and, while it is still in early days, sooner than later the platform will find its takers. Of course, the company needs to work on developing the app eco-system for the platform.

So what makes Windows Phone 8 different from the existing bunch? Windows as a desktop platform is the most popular PC version OS (followed by Mac OS X), and its versions like Win 98 and Win XP have been runaway hits. This popularity was meant to translate from desktop to mobile (via Windows Phone 8) but, due to some restrictions and limitations, the platform has not found many takers.

Smartphone users are still unsure about the viability of the platform due to its high adoption cost (though it is changing gradually). Also, on the hardware front, manufacturers have not been given too much leverage to create a product that will attract consumers.

Interface-wise, Windows Phone 8 is a refreshing change from the monotony of Android and iOS with its clean look and also how it represents what Microsoft has been aiming for over the years. The previous version of Windows Phone 8, Windows Phone 7.5, was criticised for its rigidity as it lacked many features. But things have changed with Windows Phone 8 as Microsoft has tried its best to work on those shortcomings and offer a product that is market-ready.

Features of Windows Phone 8

Live Tiles. This feature has captivated many users and there is a rich feel about how the tiles have been used. Unlike Android,